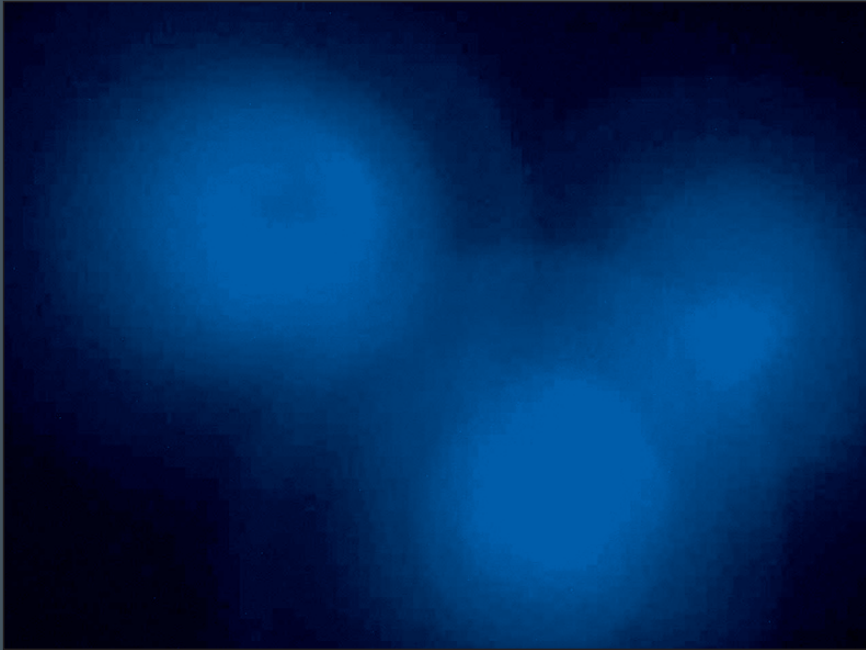


How to See a Work of Art in Total Darkness

Darby English



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Darby English

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Fantasias of the Museum

When Fred Wilson came to installation art in the late 1980s, he was a midcareer artist, trained as a sculptor. After a number of years supporting himself with jobs as a guard, curator, and freelance educator in museums, he decided to turn the focus of his practice to aspects of these institutions that he found wanting.¹ Reading James Clifford's landmark 1988 study *The Predicament of Culture* had left a particular impression. Clifford's study of converging definitions of "culture," and specifically the ways they position their most privileged objects in relation to others, appealed to Wilson's diasporic sensibilities and became a touchstone for his thinking about the Western museum's disposition toward both the "non-West" and the cultural minorities more local to it.² Wilson concluded that "Ethnographic displays create a distance between cultures that doesn't need to be there. This difference cuts off any connections and flattens out the complexity of our relations."³ He began to consider what it would mean to make art that collapsed that distance and reestablished those connections. The material results of Wilson's ongoing investigation can thus far be divided into two categories. The

first involves the detailed fabrication of museum-like arrangements of objects. The second mode—exemplified by his *Mining the Museum*, a 1992–93 reinstallation of the third-floor galleries at the Maryland Historical Society—entails the modification of preexisting spaces in actual institutions, wherein Wilson enters the scenario with the understanding that every transformable element in a given context is fair game. These elements must be accessible to him (whether on display or not, whether “art” or not) because the museum itself, it has been said, is Wilson’s medium. He works with not only its structure and categories but all the space it demarcates and everything in it. The first part of the present discussion considers the degree to which the idea of the museum conditions and informs what remains Wilson’s defining work in the latter mode, *Mining the Museum*, establishing the repertoire of gestures possible within it and thereby setting its limits.

In his earliest work, mostly executed in the first mode, Wilson focused on fabricating objects of his own invention. He created free-standing installations and sculptural programs from materials, and in configurations, representative of how display determines art objects. Then Wilson arranged them in specially dressed spaces, as do museums on a larger scale. These works propose agendas of alternative (and unlikely) possibility for the museum, articulating unwritten narratives of the sometimes iniquitous events that make possible but are anesthetized by museums’ static representations of culture. They imaginatively render unto the museum the capacity to account for the kinds of action needed to establish cultural authority; to bear out, as if confessionally, the particular stories that shore up its rhetorical foundation. No longer a bazaar where Western civilization proudly legitimizes its own art and culture’s highest and most hegemonic ideals, Wilson’s mock museums make visible relations of power, not just relations of meaning, and integrate these into the larger institutional story told.⁴ In this way, and be-

cause Wilson maintained a variance from project to project, his early museology conceptualizes the museum as a form of action instead of a finished achievement.

From 1988 to 1992, Wilson filled these faux museum galleries with borrowed artwork, high-quality reproductions, items from his own collection, and store-bought goods. The first and largest such installation, *Rooms with a View: The Struggle between Culture, Content, and the Context of Art* (1988; fig. 3.1), occupied three rooms at a Bronx gallery that Wilson was directing at the time.⁵ To create it, the artist borrowed artworks and distributed them among the rooms according to type: a crowded and heavily documented ethnographic gallery, “The Ethnographic Museum”; a well-appointed and thickly hung salon, “The Turn-of-the-Century Salon”; and a spare modern art gallery, “The White Box.” Wilson created three powerful, but also shifting and opposed, senses of ambience in which viewers could read the distinct interpretive style honored in each configuration: fetishized, stylized, and rarefied. To observe the differences among these types while also feeling their divergent ways of positioning viewers vis-à-vis objects—knowing all the while that each was a subset of the same deconstructive operation—hurled the viewer into an awareness of the falsely neutral formal conventions of museum settings themselves. Indeed, in that moment of awareness, it was open to question whether one was a viewer or a self-conscious witness of museum discourse at work—a condition that an undisturbed conception of the “the viewer” precisely forecloses. Wilson’s confabulations of vocabularies of display shifted the basis of viewer experience from continuity to radical discontinuity, inserting a strangeness at the heart of an experience many of us prize for its tranquil familiarity.

Following *Rooms with a View*, Wilson exercised his critical analysis of museum languages in smaller, more focused projects. These drew



3.1 Fred Wilson, *Rooms with a View: The Struggle between Culture, Content, and the Context of Art*, 1988. Mixed media. Detail: "The Turn-of-the-Century Salon." Installation view, Longwood Arts Gallery, New York. Courtesy the artist and Pace Wildenstein.

attention to the museum's inability to account fully for change or historical and cultural specificity within its synoptic, narrative framework. Such works were particularly adept at showing how the museum's organizational logic at times uncannily resembles colonialism's by placing under evasive differences that might prove inhospitable to "mission," and "utter[ing] an archaic colonial 'otherness,' speaking in riddles, obliterating proper names and proper places."⁶ By the time Wilson opened *Panta Rhei: A Gallery of Ancient Classical Art* in 1992 (fig. 3.2), his viewpoint on the museum's selective historicism and unreflective culturalism had become at once more pointed and more topical. *Panta Rhei*, Greek for "all things in flux," was more deftly compositional and evocative of the sculptural practice in which Wilson had trained, and reflected the expanded scope of his methodology. For *Panta Rhei*, Wilson painted a space the pale shade of blue traditionally reserved for the display of antiquities and filled it with white plaster casts of classical Greek sculpture, most on pedestals. Wilson interspersed the casts among smaller reproductions of Egyptian sculpture in plaster and terracotta colored gray and black. This last gesture addressed the formation of the dominant art historical concepts "ancientness" and "classicalness" as pointedly Greek. More importantly, it repositioned those concepts as expressive of the cross-cultural encounters, with North Africa among other places, that necessitated their solidification but are eviscerated in common usage. Wilson nestled among all these sculptures an Atlas figure that, rather than supporting its characteristic globe, labors under a pile of Western art history survey texts while standing upon a number of books on non-Western subjects, including one on African art. As Lois Nesbitt wrote, "We all know by now that European and American art historians have stacked the cards heavily in favor of the classical tradition at the expense of African and Far Eastern cultures . . . [but] in Wilson's sculpture, the Western tomes supplant the globe: they



3.2 Fred Wilson, *Panta Rhei: A Gallery of Ancient Classical Art*, 1992. Mixed media. Installation view, Metro Pictures, New York. Courtesy the artist and Pace Wildenstein. ALSO PLATE 4.

are the world we have been taught.”⁷ Wilson conveyed this lesson in reverse in a nearby work, which sees the head of a decapitated, white Artemis figure forcefully replaced by that of Bast, an Egyptian cat goddess, whose myth was likely the source of Artemis’s own (fig. 3.3).

Dotting the scene with Artemis’s severed head and scattering plaster debris on the floor, Wilson staged a kind of violent restitution of the order that was upset to establish the classical one. Indeed, between the strewn plaster and the off-balancing effect of the overstuffed pedestals and numerous headless, bodiless, or otherwise incomplete figures, *Panta Rhei* demanded that the viewer negotiate the space physically. This gave force to the real-world resonance of Wilson’s symbolic actions. For Wilson understated the import of his installation when he described it as “a discussion about the classical history of Western civilization and how it was shifted by early-nineteenth-century and eighteenth-century prejudices about the world.”⁸ With the word “shift” Wilson also remarked a more immediate transformation under way as litigious contemporary disputes arose over the rightful ownership of both antiquity as an idea and the physical artifacts associated with it. No doubt, cognizance of these disputes may have increased some viewers’ sense of disorientation and unease in *Panta Rhei*’s already nervous-making setting. In this way *Panta Rhei* transcended mere visual museology to become political art in the deepest sense: both topical and concisely expressive of a real-time conflict raging outside its frame.

Panta Rhei represents an important advance in Wilson’s practice, in requiring viewers literally to negotiate the matter as well as the subject of the installation, and to engage the altogether real currency of its content. More, it centered its action on radically altering the context of, and in some cases destroying, the very pedagogical instruments—the busts commonly used as models in drawing classes; the survey texts—by means of which old models might persist unrevised. By moving among



3.3 Fred Wilson, *Panta Rhei: A Gallery of Ancient Classical Art*, 1992. Mixed media. Detail: *Artemis/Bast*. Courtesy the artist and Pace Wildenstein.

these different levels of interpretation and critique, *Panta Rhei* injected these “ancient” scenes with an unflinching contemporaneity, thereby showing the representation of culture to be a dynamic, productive social force by becoming one itself.⁹

Following *Panta Rhei*, Wilson began to work by commission in actual museums. Many of these projects have seen the artist reimagine museums against themselves by temporarily introducing disorienting changes into their midst, some subtle and some dramatic. Wilson has relocated, unearthed, and reaccented collection materials and environmental features in order to put institutional, and often institution-specific, conventions into critical perspective. This has involved everything from object placement, to the voices of museum labels and tours, to lighting and encasement protocols. For instance, as part of *The Museum: Mixed Metaphors*, a 1993 project at the Seattle Art Museum, Wilson activated an incidental passageway by aiming an overhead light at a water fountain; in another location, he placed a cleaning cart on a pedestal in the middle of a paintings gallery.¹⁰ The point of this second mode of installation, it seems, has been to show that even the slightest departure from the museum’s prevailing order can jostle viewers into an alertness to the prior and total rationalization of all its functions, spaces, and holdings. While Wilson has completed a number of projects in this vein, I will focus the present discussion on *Mining the Museum* because the exhibition sought to apply this strategy with citywide relevance, to respond through the Maryland Historical Society to contemporary conditions in Baltimore, as home to some of this country’s most infamous and stressful race antagonism.¹¹ As American cities go, Baltimore is one of the most “loaded” with respect to Wilson’s concern with the institutionalization of differences. The city’s history reflects, to many, an ambivalence about race that is endemic to its geographic circumstances. For Baltimore is a border city in a border state, and the elites who formed

its culture-historical base in the nineteenth century comprised both northern abolitionists and proslavery interests politically oriented to the South. Not talking about race, it is often said, has long been a precondition of peace in the city. With *Mining the Museum*, then, Wilson proposed to do just that.

First it is necessary to familiarize ourselves with the language of intervention that Wilson's 1992 installation used. Wilson has insisted that he grew his institutional critique out of his own experience working at various levels of the museum profession during the 1980s but nowhere finding his heritage reflected to his satisfaction. Importantly, this same period saw the emergence of many distinct critical visions of art institutions, some rooted in the ambience of multiculturalism and mobilized from within existing institutional frameworks. In this respect the reclamatory aspect of Wilson's project bears the marks of a larger project fomented in a period many will remember by "The Decade Show": the international conversation generated in response to "Into the Heart of Africa" at the Royal Ontario Museum, which made a flagging attempt to address Canada's contributions to colonialism; and the 1991 and especially 1993 Whitney Biennials, which became so much lion fodder for conservative critics who imagine cultural diversity and cultural advancement to be definitionally unrelated pursuits.¹² Yet despite Wilson's understandable reluctance to reduce his work to its precedents and the relative newness of interventionary multiculturalism, we cannot overlook the historical fact that the institutions of art had been subjected to trenchant critique for years, albeit with little focus on their specifically ethnographic, race-hierarchizing functions.¹³ In important ways, Wilson's work reorients formal, rhetorical, and conceptual actions already performed, and attention to the broader arc of its antecedents and contemporaries can only bring his work more sharply into focus.¹⁴

Since at least the late 1960s, the museum and its distance from the grain of sociopolitical life have been generative subjects for large numbers of conceptual, performance, and multimedia artists wishing to be seen to “generate a legitimate opinion independently of the institution.”¹⁵ This art shared the theoretical premise that, as cultural authorities vested to represent the past to the present and the present to itself, these institutions purchase their authority at very real costs to the variously constituted publics they ostensibly serve. Thus when museums became viable subjects for art, the stress frequently fell upon their function as organs for the reproduction of material and conceptual frameworks of culture, and what became known as institutional critique often entailed a flouting of traditional aesthetic categories now viewed as complicit with that reproductive process. This functioning was seen to reflect and affect everything from the appearance and representation of artistic creation itself (e.g., Marcel Duchamp’s *Boîte-en-valise* [1941], Marcel Broodthaers’s *Musée d’Art Moderne, Département des Aigles* [1969–72], Mel Bochner’s *Measurements* [from 1969]), to notions of where art was possible and where it was supposed not to be (Robert Smithson’s non-sites, Daniel Buren’s contribution to the 1968 Salon de Mai), to private institutions’ imbrication with civic processes (e.g., Hans Haacke’s *MoMA Poll* [1970]). The difficulty of exiting the art economy altogether led many to confront the “institutional frame” by illuminating it from within. Bochner’s *Measurements*, for instance, appeared in galleries, but, in marking the literal parameters of spaces and objects in inches and feet (units derived from the body), disposed themselves in a vigorously unartlike way: they accented the grammar of relations that the transcendent experience of art must suspend. Others, such as Smithson and Buren, took up positions both within and outside institutional space, thus thematizing the span that disjoins them as itself institutional. Buren for instance

sited his 1968 project at the Musée d'Art Moderne de la Ville de Paris, hiring men to pace the sidewalk wearing sandwichboards onto which Buren pasted his (now) trademark striped paper, which he had also installed inside the city museum.

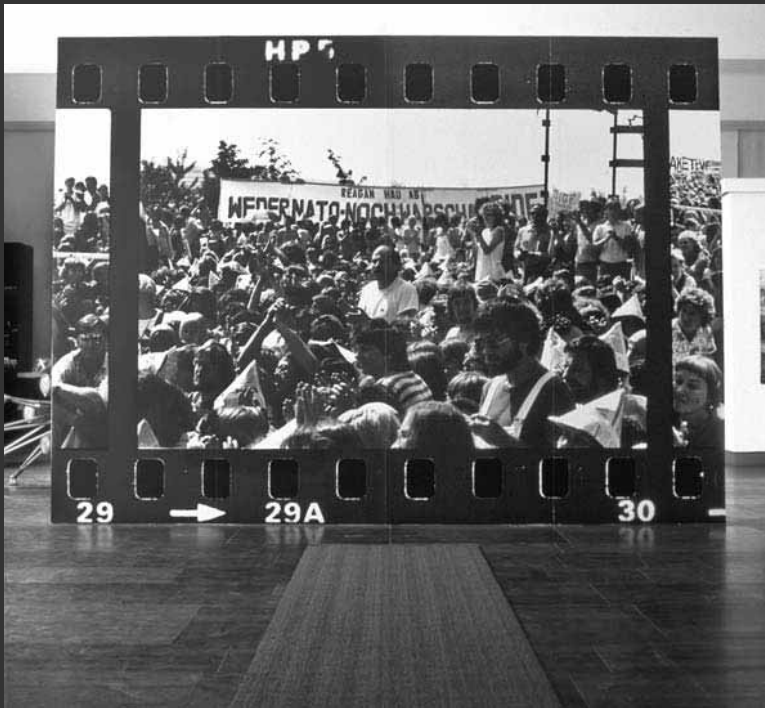
Some artists view maintaining proximity to the institution or its conventions as integral to rigorous institutional critique. Broodthaers, Buren, and Haacke, in important works dating from the late 1960s, articulated critical positions either from within the museum or by holding fast to it—or perhaps to the museum-like—as a formal and conceptual vocabulary through which to articulate its specifically social functions, and thereby to underline the discursivity that is peculiar and essential to the museum and brilliantly sublimated in its most common procedures.¹⁶ More recently, durational works and installations attached or referring to particular sites, by neoconceptualists such as Mark Dion, Andrea Fraser, Renée Green, and others, have broached the problem of museological classification. These works have focused institutional critique differently by repositioning categories of culture—such as race, gender, work, class, and nation—as well as institutional education and entertainment genres as analytic frameworks rather than mediums of knowledge. Much of this more recent work interrogates the social arrangements reflected in, or implied by, standard museum protocols, approaching philosophies and methodologies of collecting—concretized in presentational schemes deciding what and how objects are arrayed, revealed, and encountered—as readable models of social thought. These works are “later” than their conceptualist predecessors’ in another respect that makes them important background for Wilson’s projects at Baltimore: they privilege the category of experience. Deriving central components of their methodologies from what they bring to the institution—as a naturalist, say, or a black person or a feminist—they

represent difference as a fact (and a topic) repressed within typical museum functioning. At its best, this work reveals the kinetic operation of categories within the chilling stillness of conventional museological thinking; it does not simply remind us that difference exists, it discloses the means of its constitution in relations and language.¹⁷

Ostensibly, such projects draw attention to the constitutive outsides of institutions of art, insinuating “live” politics in sites where, if it manifests at all, it does so as archived (valorized) or deadened, or streamlined into celebrations of difference for its own sake (theatricalized). The ever-increasing fiscal necessity that museums position themselves as public institutions equally topical to all segments of their respective populations only heightens the importance of testing the quality of their claims according to the circumstances that actually surround them. A 1982 work by Hans Haacke is exemplary in this respect. Haacke’s *Oelgemaelde, Hommage à Marcel Broodthaers* (figs. 3.4, 3.5), created for Documenta 7 in Kassel, Germany, consisted of an oil painting of then–U.S. President Ronald Reagan closed off by stanchions with a velvet rope and situated at the end of a red carpet runner, at the opposite end of which Haacke installed a mural-sized photograph of a political demonstration. It was precisely Haacke’s point that the photograph needed its physical enormity in order to compromise even slightly the force of aesthetic-discursive tradition signaled by the gilt-framed portrait and ceremonial trappings and articulated as political by association with Reagan’s painted image. The radical disproportion between the two sides of the installation physically underscored its more symbolic messages. For Haacke’s photograph, which depicted German demonstrators protesting Reagan’s recent appearance in Kassel to express his country’s gratitude to the Germans for housing part of its nuclear arsenal, not only confronted painting with photomechanical reproduction but analogized



3.4 Hans Haacke, *Oelgemaelde, Hommage à Marcel Broodthaers*, 1982. Detail. Mixed media. Installation view, Documenta 7, Kassel. Courtesy the artist. Copyright ARS (Artists' Rights Society).



3.5 Hans Haacke, *Oelgemaelde, Hommage à Marcel Broodthaers*, 1982.
Detail. Courtesy the artist. Copyright ARS (Artists' Rights Society).

this antagonism to an incipient one between competing constituencies in the German state. As Douglas Crimp explained,

Not only did Haacke insert into this [exhibition] context a reminder of actual historical conditions, but he also reflected on the terms of current aesthetic debates. . . . But more important than these debates, Haacke's *Oelgemaelde* suggested to the viewer that the relevant history of the town of Kassel was closer than the one to which Documenta's artistic director [Rudi Fuchs, who had sought "to locate Documenta within the grand tradition of the eighteenth century"] constantly made reference. . . . Haacke's work might thus have evoked for Documenta's visitors not Kassel's glorious eighteenth-century past but its precarious present.¹⁸

By rendering the interconnection of the immediate political situation and the artwork's historical specificity, *Oelgemaelde* made palpable tensions from which Documenta officials had hoped their exhibition would provide an escape (in the form of the simple explanation: "Our culture suffers from an illusion of the media," as Fuchs put it at the time).¹⁹

Like Haacke's installation, Wilson's projects reflect the currents of the same aesthetic and academic conversations that they ultimately enter. And, as do the works of Broodthaers and Green, Wilson's understanding of the museum's cultural history bears the deep impress of the institution's relevance for colonization projects and other geopolitically consequential fruits of the consolidation of power-knowledge that animated modernity.²⁰ I make these modal comparisons neither to diminish key differences among these practices nor to locate a particular derivativeness at the heart of Wilson's practice. To the contrary, situating Wilson's approach in this way shows how he redirected the insights

attained in earlier work in ways befitting his appreciably distinctive priorities. Wilson's ability to locate traces of power relationships that might otherwise remain hidden or to pinpoint the artificiality, within the museum's structures of natural progression—by simply shifting the stresses of the statements already on hand—distinguishes his work from much of the institutional critique that preceded it. Surely another of his accomplishments certain to endure is the simple fact that, were it not for the success of Wilson's interventions, institutional critique itself might not yet have turned so fully to face the nexus of problems that race difference raises in institutions of art. Likewise, it might not have developed the (to a political artist, enviable) problem of needing now to reevaluate its relationship to a new kind of "postmodernist museum," whose public performance now includes a regular schedule of invitations whose very structure as repeated, compulsive performances indicates that the pressure is felt but precisely not taken to be a cause for thorough self-examination. Still another source of Wilson's work's value is the effect of its much-debated didacticism: for by enabling visitors to isolate and examine the rhetorics of marginalization, subordination, and exclusion that organize the museum, Wilson's projects have let them see for themselves how the institution does and does not answer to the differences brought to it by visitors.

An important difficulty remains, however. The practice of reading specific museums for and then calling out for display repressed, native inscriptions of differences—especially those kept in place through scopoc regimes, as race and gender are—risks promulgating such differences in a legibility, or clarity, that is both consistent with most extant institutional procedures and at odds with modes of living *as* different. All an institution has to do to claim responsibility for difference is to make a place (in the gallery, the collection, the board rolls, the exhibition schedule) for a force that will clarify its special character simply by

being manifest, at last, in a site that had absented it. The institution's relationship to the differential relations that comprise it, demarked or perhaps "confessed" but completely untransformed, and the integrity of the power these relations continually establish are never put into question. Because they bring the issue to a level of specificity at which the museum's abstractions are particularly dangerous, matters concerning particular locales and specific museums' appeals to "public responsibility" require a critique detailed enough to account for the singularities and differences that constitute publics and communities.²¹ As Miwon Kwon has warned, in too many of these cases, "the community is primarily defined in opposition to the forces of an oppressive dominant culture that would regulate and diffuse the efforts of those who seek greater participation. . . . This focus on the oppositional character of a community supports the habitual tendency . . . to think of the 'community' as a synonym for social groups of the marginal or underprivileged classes."²²

This is precisely the challenge that Wilson faced with *Mining the Museum*. I want to consider this installation in terms of the tension that arose between institutional statements that presented it as an exhibition for the citizens of Baltimore and the images of culture and transformational possibility that the installation itself projected.²³ I contend that if we are to take seriously its claims to interrogate "commonly held definitions of 'museum,' 'history,' 'exhibition,' 'curator,' 'artist,' 'audience,' 'community,' and 'collaboration,'" then we must also seriously evaluate what kind of statements *Mining the Museum* offered to those Baltimoreans whose histories' vanishing by the institution Wilson sought to reverse.²⁴ How were black and Native American audiences entering the Maryland Historical Society knowing that "'another' story was being told inside" expected to think the difference between *that* story and the irreducibly specific ones that large numbers of them surely already knew

from their lived experiences? The main difference, of course, is that the story on offer at the MHS was only one version—Wilson’s—of their stories, but that difference *could not be seen to make a difference* without severely limiting the project’s reach. The very logic of *Mining* depends on the conflation of a single, privileged experience, recounted in the catalogue and discussed below, with an institutionally derived, general conception not only of community but of the representational demands “it” would make on the MHS if given the opportunity.

Mining the Museum made legible the racism implicit in the Maryland Historical Society’s view of the population. In this way, the installation answered a leading concern for those situated in and around the city of Baltimore, whose starkly divisive race relations were made starker in recent decades by growing numbers of severely disenfranchised blacks, Native Americans, and Asian Americans. This situation created a certain pressure for Wilson to use *Mining*, in his words, to “root out the denial” that had left him with “a kind of tension in my body” when he had first visited the MHS.²⁵ According to the project’s organizers, the task was to marshal an “other viewpoint” on Maryland history,²⁶ and audience research was central to the year-long residency Wilson undertook in preparation for the show: “What was important to me was that I wasn’t going to understand what the Historical Society was about unless I spoke to the community in Baltimore. . . . I don’t just go into a community and say, ‘There it is. Now you have to figure it out.’”²⁷ Wilson said that this familiarization process was difficult because “Baltimore was, for me, really the nineteenth century. I was going through [the MHS’s collection of] manumission papers, the logs of slaves, and the letters . . . but I was also struck by the wealth that was there. Seeing the juxtaposition of those things was really painful.”²⁸

With *Mining*, Wilson made concrete the acute consciousness of difference that contemporary Baltimore had provoked for him. How,

then, did this manifest in the installation? What kind of image of interventionary politics is *Mining*? Given the installation's temporariness and site specificity, to speculate about such things is of course to ask a great deal of the images and anecdotes that are all that remain of it. But these materials are rich with insights into how *Mining* addressed the problem of conceptualizing marginalized communities and representing them to themselves from within a museum framework.²⁹

An image-based reading of *Mining* also agrees fundamentally with the experience one might have had visiting it. The installation worked as an image on several levels, moving viewers through a series of densely symbolic vignettes, one at a time, as they approached and entered the MHS, proceeded to its third floor, and crossed the floor from one side to the other. The first two of these vignettes—a red, green, and black Black Nationalist flag hanging outside the MHS and a video “signature” by the artist that greeted visitors in the lobby—were prefatory gestures preparing visitors for the third-floor installation. For the organizers, the flag was intended not to state Wilson's or the exhibition's politics, but rather to announce “to ‘other’ audiences that ‘another’ history was now being told inside.”³⁰ Already the course of the installation was posited as an alternative to the MHS's own narrative, rather than a consideration of the “other” as *at all times* a determining presence *within* Maryland's self-understanding. The staggering confusion of priorities here—welcome the new audience, assuage the old one, and be sure weary travelers can orient quickly to the purely experimental nature of the event—right at the top of the score—was given different expression in Wilson's televised signature. This component isolated his perspective still more completely; indeed, the literature explains it as assuring visitors that the views expressed in *Mining* were Wilson's own. In the video, Wilson affably addresses viewers with statements about the subjectivism of museum displays: “Whether they admit it or not,

curators bring who they are to the creation of exhibitions,” he says at one point. Later he invites his audience to look upon museums in general as “a place where anything can happen,” and one that should “make you think, [make] you question.”³¹ Wilson’s “signature” did significant work, although it is seldom remarked in considerations of *Mining*. Two aspects of this work need remarking here. First, Wilson affirms “who he is” in a way that counterposes an individual essence, meant to be seen as black, to an institutional essence correspondingly understood as white. This not only essentializes his position but imputes to it an institutional or collective scope within which black disputants are unimaginable; in short, it secures representativeness for an experience whose specificity will be seen subsequently to matter in only the most superficial of ways.

Second, Wilson’s signature can claim this authenticity precisely and only because the museum is good enough to recognize it—its beneficence being what makes it the spontaneous, egalitarian, mind-ennobling place that Wilson describes. Partly because of its thinly personal element, *Mining* depended a great deal on Wilson’s success in conveying specific metaphorical images of previously unseen relations to viewers. In these images, the “other” viewers were invited to find points of identification. By showing them that they had always had a place in the MHS, if only as an abiding absence, they made the museum “theirs” as much as (in fact, just like) Wilson had made it his.

Thus, in an early gallery dimly lit and hung with paintings—three of which included black figures in marginal or subservient positions—Wilson illuminated the figures with spotlights and hung labels asking leading questions on their behalf: “Who am I? Where did I come from? Where did I go? What do I dream?” (fig. 3.6). More didactic than the scenes that would follow, this arrangement effectively revealed Wilson’s interrogative methodology, a mode of critiquing the institution that



3.6 Fred Wilson, *Mining the Museum*, 1992–93. Mixed media. Installation view, Maryland Historical Society, Baltimore. Detail: paintings gallery. Courtesy the artist and Pace Wildenstein. ALSO PLATE 5.

inverts its standpoint and then phrases as questions what the dominant culture would issue as declaratives. Most striking about this outcome is the stability upon which it depends, at whose preservation it seems to direct the bulk of its critical interest. The majority of the vignettes were more complex, but none could be described as unstable. Indeed, as Wilson stated, he intended to steady precarious balances like the one that overtook him when he first arrived.

Upon arriving on the third floor, viewers first encountered a large silver trophy globe emblazoned with the word “Truth” and set in a vitrine surrounded with several empty Plexiglas mounts (fig. 3.7). Six marble pedestals flanked this setup, three white ones placed to the right and three black to the left. Atop the white pedestals rested the portrait busts of three men whom the context would suggest were significant personages in state lore. In fact, as wall labels informed viewers, they are Napoleon Bonaparte (whose brother Jérôme’s son left collections to the Society), Andrew Jackson, and Henry Clay—none of whom ever lived in Maryland.³² In contrast, the three black pedestals supported nothing, but their labels name Benjamin Banneker, Frederick Douglass, and Harriet Tubman—all Marylanders whose images appear nowhere in the MHS collection. This opening vignette relied on viewers’ nearly assured recognition of the indispensability of Banneker, Douglass, and Tubman for Maryland history. Because the white figures belong to a familiar and rather standard type of genealogy, the question of their belonging is superfluous: they belong by fiat. The practice of collecting itself was on display, not as a generalized form of engaging culture possessively but as a deliberative and exclusionary process of state identity formation. In Wilson’s modification, the MHS collection announced itself as a representative personification of Maryland’s historical culture. Its tendencies of collection and display, the viewer learned, both enacted and denied social recognitions, rationalized identifications, and even erased the



3.7 Fred Wilson, *Mining the Museum*, 1992–93. Mixed media. Detail: pedestals. Courtesy the artist and Pace Wildenstein.

evidence of certain lives according to the prevailing, indeed the founding, racial logic of its native context.

Clearly the arrangement of these sculptures and pedestals for the show forced back upon the MHS questions begged by the lack of proportionate representation for the state's racial minorities. (Somewhat less clearly, it allowed the MHS *to be seen* confronting such questions.) Elsewhere, *Mining* accomplished this questioning with the startling force of key presences established by Wilson's excavation (or "mining," in the sense of the title) from the basement of objects previously deemed unfit for public viewing.³³ Some of the most dramatic of these evidenced a significant black presence at the MHS, though in nearly every instance it is marked by subordination and outright exclusion.

An area titled "Metalwork, 1793–1880" included a vitrine containing metal household items (fig. 3.8). Nearby, a nondescript gray-and-white-painted wooden dollhouse was mounted on a pedestal. The theme of this vignette was the life of the black domestic laborer in the house of Maryland culture, though this is hardly disclosed by its title, itself a comment on the domesticating breadth of museological categorizing practices. Inside the vitrine, Wilson had neatly arrayed a gleaming silver tea service and set of beverage cups to surround a crudely forged, darkly patinated manacle. The setup makes the sharp tactile contrasts seem pat, until the social imagination personifies the arrangement. One then realizes that Wilson has carefully blocked the scene to evoke both a servicing action ("Your tea...") and the server's violent besiegement. The closed dollhouse nearby emboldened this image of hemming in, serving simultaneously as a kind prison for the black-faced figurine of a domestic laborer standing in the living room (seemingly at a loss) and as "home" for the small black dog who sits obediently beside its master, a plastic statuette of a white boy. The implicit dialogue between these cast-metal objects, intimate and discomfiting, is somewhat contextualized



3.8 Fred Wilson, *Mining the Museum*, 1992–93. Mixed media. Detail: “Metalwork, 1793–1880.” Courtesy the artist and Pace Wildenstein.

but more precisely determined by the dates given in the vignette's title ("Metalwork, 1793–1880"), as 1793 saw the introduction of the first anti-slavery legislation and 1880 the abolition of slavery in Cuba, the institution's last official stronghold. The dollhouse's context, then, is the abolition of an institution that continued to speak through apparently benign cultural forms despite its formal dissolution.

A few galleries later, viewers encountered another well-known arrangement, "Cabinetmaking, 1820–1960," which occupied a blood-red gallery. Here, Wilson's arrangement desublimated the image of enforced subservience by dramatically evoking scenes of the pursuit, capture, and eventual punishment of (poor) blacks by their (rich, white) oppressors. The most striking image was a hunting rifle mounted high on a pedestal, its barrel aimed at a group of mallard decoys flanking a wooden Zouave puppet (a racist caricature in a type of garb inspired by elite Algerian troops and later adapted to uniform an eccentric Civil War regiment).³⁴ Like metalwork, cabinetmaking is a slightly old-fashioned genericism, but for woodcraft—a category that includes things from decoys and puppets to punt guns and paper. In Wilson's usage, "cabinetmaking" emphasized by ironic understatement the brutality of the actions implied. Behind the rifle hung eight reproductions of runaway slave posters. Wilson guided viewers' reading of these posters by using raised, printed slivers of foam core to highlight, or target, passages revealing the compounding rhetorical violences of the posters themselves: "Leg which is a little crooked from having once been broken"; "lump or mark on his shin occasioned by a kick" are two examples of the descriptions slave masters gave their human property. At the other end of the same room, Wilson figured the culmination of the slave hunt: there sat four nineteenth-century Victorian chairs upon pedestals arrayed to face what the catalogue describes as "Baltimore's whipping post," gifted to the MHS by the City Jail Board in 1963 (fig. 3.9). While one is accustomed to seeing



3.9 Fred Wilson, *Mining the Museum*, 1992–93. Mixed media. Detail:
“Cabinetmaking, 1820–1960.” Courtesy the artist and Pace Wildenstein.
ALSO PLATE 6.

empty or taped-off chairs in museums, seeing the whipping post is all the more harrowing when one visualizes the very different kinds of person to which the post and chairs are suited. In this arrangement, the drama of the post becomes the supplement to the chairs that restores both to a social function within a specific relation of power, yet in re-staging lynching as a kind of living-room leisure sport, Wilson's arrangement draws this practice into direct correlation with those others implied in the dollhouse and the "Metalwork" vitrine. The dark poetry of the whipping post as proscenium gave this section the feel of a perverse luxury, a kind of "grand" finale to measures taken by more direct means elsewhere in the room such as guns and slave hunts. Moreover, since none of the objects exceeds the category "cabinetmaking," Wilson's spectacle made a show of play inside the conservational protocols that manage objects and themes within the institutional order.

These gestures go beyond merely revealing the support that diversely categorized things lend to the messaging and enforcement functions of categories themselves. They establish "home" as a simultaneously capacious and airless symbology that is also indispensable to the MHS's public function, regardless of whose story is being told. Wilson's reconfiguration of the dollhouse evokes this patently by exposing it as an ideological toy from whose proper engagement lessons in domination and subordination can be learned. The uneasy, quotidian charm of the genre scene between the tea service and the manacle makes a similar point. *Mining's* most powerful reconnoitering of the home trope, however, is achieved in "Cabinetmaking." Chairs don't age like dollhouses or iron; nor do they project preciousness in the manner of silver sets or well-conserved old papers. Rather, as mere chairs, haphazardly arranged, their aura is that of the domestic familiar, which lends Wilson's arrangement the uncanny feel of a setting for an after-hours diversion. These

suggestions work in concert with the chairs' siting in a state historical society to extend the notion of home to the state, to state identity, and most eerily, to the totality of depicted or implied relations those formations include, *now*. The categories themselves—painting, metalwork, cabinetmaking, and others—were but convenient epistemological frameworks in which to model the larger predicament identified, though not problematized, by *Mining*: that is, the election of a single, simple relational dynamic—white/nonwhite, or dominant/oppressed—in which to “provide a strategy for the audience to reclaim the terrain of the museum for itself.”³⁵ What Ira Berlin writes in the catalogue is true: “‘Metalwork . . .’ makes clear that the history of American Indians, Africans, and Europeans can never be understood in isolation from each other. Wilson explores this conjunction by a close examination of the ubiquitous violence that has informed relations among American Indians, Africans, Europeans, and their descendants from the beginning of Maryland’s history.”³⁶ But the most creative actions Wilson committed in creating *Mining* showed, did not “examine,” these violences. Likewise they did not see violences as “informing” relations but defining them, establishing their limits if not their very possibility. What were audiences to take away from the reinstallation that they didn’t already know? The kinds of cultural conjunction that *Mining* modeled, the sort of dwelling it temporarily became for that “other audience,” did little more than reaffirm the not unreasonable commonplace notion that being “at home in Maryland” is a kind of being that is pervaded at almost all levels by an alienating and chillingly static ensemble of race relations.

Owing perhaps to the historical and representative functions imposed, Wilson’s vignettes, the centerpieces of the installation, reproduced an image of static antagonism that itself reinforced the notion of intrinsically differential, or essentialist, cultural space. Instead it offered a radically nonintegrative picture of difference, one which in fact con-

solidated a state power in highlighting and honoring, if creatively re-configuring, the symbolic means that sustain the extant social order as a form (really a *practice*) of containment. Even if visitors understood it as the result of an idiosyncratic action signaling the possibility of change, *Mining* limited the imagination of that change to what might be accomplished within an ultimately immutable structure. The transformation *Mining* represented was one from concealment to admission (a considerable step by any measure), not from alienation to the possibility of its overcoming. Moreover, its impermanence left no question that the MHS intended the action to be seen as representative—at the very least, of its having taken place, of the organization's investment in ameliorative justice. Probably it also seemed a means to satisfy and perhaps quell for a time a still-abstract black community's demands for representation. Once things were returned to order and the Society added recognition of these demands to its log of community services, there might have remained no urgency to interrogate the structural relations among the parties involved—those relations whose avoidance made the work so easy to do. Thus unchanged in substance from any prior historical moment, the MHS's relationship to the "black community" post-*Mining the Museum* might plausibly have been predicted from the start—not only by the cynical, but by the assumptions of any reasonable person who was vaguely familiar with the cultural politics of Baltimore and such institutions' conventional conceptions of self-interest and social responsibility.

It is not difficult to recognize in the rhetoric and mechanics of *Mining* some quintessentially American ideas about how to do critical representation in a pluralistic context. This attitude toward the grossly uneven cultural geography of the United States imagines "reckoning with identity" to mean simply designating it. Thus it domesticates differences by thinking in terms of units such as "communities of difference,"

but seldom in terms of the contingent singularities that muddy differences and, by extension, make communities alternately hard to come by, difficult to live with, and at times painful to inhabit. Here I refer to the “common notion of the community as a coherent and unified social formation—equally valorized by the neoconservatives and the liberal left—which often serves exclusionary and authoritarian purposes in the very name of the opposite.”³⁷ Among other effects, this approach to community interest rationalizes a view of what “race” and “racism” mean that cannot reckon with the ways contradictions (of politics, gender, generation, but also among *sheer subjects*) register within and not just among the formations, as functions of time, local specificity, and desire—all of which affect, by dispersing, the kinds of interest that obtain with each brandishment of a given “community” in public rhetoric. Racism and race with it, this attitude suggests, are only ever what have been perpetrated here all along. It speaks of (and to) race and racism in the same tongue, that of the “black experience” which forms what Hall calls “the ground—the terrain of the ‘lived’—where consciousness and conditions intersect,”³⁸ establishing a homology of ways of being black that guarantees the integrity of the “black perspective.”

If with *Mining* Wilson was “making the museum mine” for a time, then what kinds of desire did the work satisfy? The question is relevant because the notion of shared outlook carries over that of shared desire. Another function of desire is to express concern when ostensibly critical interventionary art practices exhibit little will to think out from—to fantasize—the fixed relation we always already know the “black community” to occupy with respect to its local houses of culture. What would it mean not simply to excavate existing black presences but actually to exploit that presence to alter or to envision the altering of the very structural forms that make the domestication of culture possible? At its most general, this would be a deeply speculative project—per-

haps not quite an intervention without a museum *but nearly so*, inasmuch as within such a project the museum and its ethnographers would exceed themselves exactly so as to find new positions with respect to each other. As one way to begin such a radical speculation, the investigator might shun the very framework of the visit, the interested but transient passing-through which, structurally or as a form of experience, promotes the falsehood that the cultural institution is less a persistent problem than an occasional nuisance. It envisions a new form of cultural institution, one that responds to the instability in our (anybody's) styles of imagining what it means, in and beyond that type of representational framework, to inhabit the bodies, communities, and scripts singly authored by cultures. Because these are themselves institutional concepts without which there would be nothing to feel or discover in representative cultural institutions, such a practice would relativize the categories institutions assign, highlighting their unique contributions to the procedures which construct and position subjects of culture.³⁹

Prioritizing cultural processes over representative objects, declining the invitation to produce images, whether of unrelievably horrid conditions or of singular triumphant personalities, that effectively stop culture; avoiding the calcification of a "black perspective" that channels racialized consciousness into a worldview we can accept so long as we're getting ours; formulating representations of social conditions that reflect racism's own transformation with shifts in the terrain of the lived—this, perhaps, is what it would look like to value the state of transitoriness, of always-passing-through, which throws open the structures of both traveler and site. What would it mean to reverse the question as posed by *Mining*, to use "culture" and "community" to ask *how* the museum means, what are *its* conditions of appearance and how might they be reformulated so as to make it truly strange to us? All this is a way of

asking what fantasies might have to be indulged and forsaken in order to visualize these institutions not only as they make (or do not make) themselves available to us, but as we imagine they could be.

In the remainder of this chapter, I will pursue these questions as they bear on the deployment of fantasy in another Baltimore-based, museum-sited work, Isaac Julien's 2003 film installation *Baltimore*. The definition of fantasy operative here conjoins the work of two practitioners of British cultural studies, Stuart Hall and Elizabeth Cowie. In Hall's text, the problem is the conduct of cultural studies toward the practice of imagining. Hall imagines a cultural studies that does not simply consider or survey imaginative practices, but partakes of them. Thus Hall insinuates abstraction squarely in the domain of cultural critique:

To think about or analyze the complexity of the real, the act of the practice of thinking is required; and this necessitates the use of the power of abstraction and analysis, the formation of concepts with which to cut into the complexity of the real, in order precisely to reveal and bring to light relationships and structures which cannot be visible to the naive naked eye, and which can neither present nor authenticate themselves.⁴⁰

The important point about this methodological challenge is that it identifies fantasization as crucial for analyses of culture aimed at producing specific changes in the appearance of what is right in front of our noses precisely by thinking what is not. Hall's references to the "complexity of the real," as that which such analyses "cut into," do not yield to a simple

practice of capturing the actuality of the problem at hand. Rather they try to give critical presence to the means that produce identities but can “neither present nor authenticate themselves” because their success requires them to remain camouflaged. Such an effort requires one to dismantle given orders and objects of knowledge, through an ingression of “unthinkables” such as one that introduces into the museum certain sets of relations that its standard provisions do not, or cannot, account for.

If Hall helps us to think fantasy’s utility as a strategic abstraction for thinking the “complexity of the real,” Cowie’s construction pulls that strategy across the brink of fantasy proper, supplementing the patently analytical sense it retains in Hall’s formulation with a creative one well suited to a consideration of *Baltimore*, which in fact does both kinds of work. Cowie begins from Laplanche and Pontalis’s account, where fantasy is “the reverie, that form of novelette, both stereotyped and infinitely variable, which the subject composes and relates to himself in a waking state.” Continuing, she observes that,

rather than a notion of revelation, making visible what we would not otherwise be able to see—as with a microscope allowing us to see bacteria etc. invisible to the “naked” eye—fantasy... has come to mean the making visible, present, of what isn’t there, of what can never directly be seen. . . . [I]t is difficult to therefore avoid defining the word in terms of what it is not, the world of reality. . . . This psychical reality of which fantasy is the nucleus has an effect on and for the subject just as much as the material, physical world may have. In analyzing fantasy, it is not a criterion that there be any factual basis for the fantasy “in reality” or that there be a wish for it to “really happen,” rather the criterion is the level of “reality” the fantasy has for and in the psychical system of the subject.⁴¹

The special value of Cowie's account for the present discussion is the power it grants fantasy to aid the subject in declining, through decidedly personal action, a given domain's rules of representability. Whatever Wilson's intentions with *Mining*, the structuring of the project around an assumed identification between Wilson and the underserved audience,⁴² combined with its rigid model of intercultural interchange, foreclosed the possibility of seeing *Mining* as consequent upon a private meditation. Another kind of museum fantasy asks how the complexity of the real is to bear its coexistence with, and dependency upon, institutions arrayed against its very complexity. The fantasizing I am using Hall and Cowie to describe intends to stay close to the subject, but wishes to avoid the kind of thematization of black subjectivity that limited *Mining*. The practice of fantasy I am suggesting *Baltimore* exemplifies is keyed to the enlargement of the scope of thinkable relations in a given realm. It achieves this broadening in part through the insistently public dimension of its fantasization. Not to be confused with felicities or inventions for their own sake, this practice stake a claim on behalf of a subject in need of declining a certain reality *in favor of a less certain one*. A function of a subject's psychical reality, it translates this reality outward into "the act of the practice of thinking," and pleasures openly in the "realism of the illusionism."⁴³ So rather than facilitating the disclosure of inner truths to a defying world or attempts to make real what isn't, this practice of "abstraction and analysis" opens the subject's borders to examine their formation in cultural processes (in history, language, relations). Within this practice, it is axiomatic that every subject's "limit" entails both a boundary to be recognized and a threshold that is continually crossed.

When such a practice specularizes fantasy, as does *Baltimore*, our concern for what Cowie calls "the content of the contingent as such" must be conditioned by the terms of the material's presentation. And of

course it matters a great deal that *Baltimore* is a film, its very mode offering up fantasy in what is also an undeniably real experience for viewers. Indeed this film convention is itself among the objects of *Baltimore*'s critique, for film, like the museum, is a means by which dominant structures of desire are given "accessible" public form. Yet for these same reasons, *Baltimore* is unconflicted in its complicity with the genre and its dependence upon its charge for the viewing subject. Thus *Baltimore*'s characterological and diegetic movement in, out of, and through private museum and anonymous urban spaces only but suggests a larger interest in the coherence of the "cultural institution" and of the supposition of its inherent realism—given the number of contingencies that specific relations and contexts place upon each.

Baltimore is an eleven-and-one-half-minute film that Julien shot in sixteen-millimeter format for projection onto three monumental screens.⁴⁴ It stars Melvin Van Peebles, the renowned Hollywood film director and actor who created and played the title character in *Sweetback's Baadasssss Song* (1971), a seminal film in the genre known as blaxploitation. *Baltimore* follows Van Peebles's character through three Baltimore institutions—the Walters Art Museum, the George Peabody Library, and the Great Blacks in Wax Museum—where he is stalked by Afro-Cyborg, described by Julien as "a femme fatale who traverses stereotypes of black power, Blaxploitation, and black science fiction" (fig. 3.10).⁴⁵ *Baltimore* figures this traversal by transforming her appearance three times over its short duration. Before proceeding along their serpentine path through these sites, the characters emerge from the streets of Baltimore. Thus the film opens with a three-screen wide-angle shot of the city's vast, recently developed harborside fascia before telescoping, with a quick cut, to a pedestrian point of view on the thickly settled streets of one of Baltimore's black ghettos. Van Peebles and his adversary appear, one each on the two outer screens, before converging



3.10 Isaac Julien, *Baltimore*, 2003. Three-screen DVD installation with sound, dimensions variable. Still: cyborg eyes. Courtesy the artist and Metro Pictures.

at the Wax Museum, where they independently review its collection of effigies of celebrated black women and men. There are over one hundred wax figures in the museum's collection today, but Julien's camera scans the scene with a darkened lens, briefly spotlighting figures including those of Elijah Muhammad and Malcolm X, positioned shoulder-to-shoulder and grinning, the display concealing the fact that they were nemeses at the time of X's assassination; Colin Powell; popular entertainment personalities; and two graphic, dramatic full-scale exhibitions, "Into the Hold: The Slave Ship Experience," a chilling, full-size replica of a slave ship stowed with human cargo, and "The Struggle against Lynching: Lessons for Today."

Baltimore utilizes the Victorian-era Peabody Library's stack room—a five-story space with ornamental cast-iron balconies, massive skylight, and black-and-white marble floor—as a transitional space between the Wax Museum, the Walters Art Museum, and the city itself, the characters passing through it several times during the film. Like the characters themselves, each of these spaces—the Walters, a museum built upon two industrialist brothers' private collections and bequeathed to the city of Baltimore in 1931 "for the benefit of the public"; the Great Blacks in Wax Museum, founded in 1980 to promote the study and preservation of African-American history by giving children "a yardstick by which to measure the struggles";⁴⁶ and the Peabody, an icon of the Victorian-era conceptualization of "higher learning"—functions as a symbol of stylized culture poised to reflect and impart universal values. The two characters are filmed alone in these institutions, at once communing and at odds with them—apart from the crush of a crowd reenacting en masse the reverent protocol of museumgoing. They occupy the Peabody stack room together only momentarily and even then without direct encounter. Thus each is seen to relate to the spaces in a subject-, not object-determinate way, and Julien's filmic perception of the spaces shows us this, portraying the institutions as differently as their reading is staged

distinctively by each shape-shifting “visitor.” *Baltimore* thus constructs the *visit* as the context of a possible performance, an effective enactment of subjectivity upon a ritual that would otherwise structure it.

Julien films the streets of working-class Baltimore as similarly desolate (fig. 3.11), such that they echo both the cold vitality of the wax museum and the vision of utopia offered up in an anonymous Renaissance painting of *The Ideal City*, a cornerstone of the Walters’s collection. Van Peebles is seen viewing the painting up close, the encounter evoking, though less dramatically, the site of the city that served as Sweetback’s battleground. *Baltimore*’s shifting of time and place reaches a climax in the final sequences, which see a number of the wax figurines from the Great Blacks in Wax Museum congregate in one of the Walters’ luxurious painting galleries. Van Peebles encounters his own wax doppelganger before Julien closes the film by flanking this effigy with those of Malcolm X and Martin Luther King Jr. (figs. 3.12, 3.13).

Baltimore crosses sociality and culture, users and spaces, in a fantasy vision of a borderless museum articulated in a direct but unresolved dialogue with Baltimore proper. A comparison with *Mining the Museum* is apposite because *Baltimore* models a “mining” of a very different sort—chiefly, its implicit account of subjectivity is open, not closed, and accomplished through negotiation, not assertion—in seeking not to establish an equivalency between institutional representations and actual conditions, but rather a multiplication of relationships that might be imagined to exist both between and among viewers and institutions, pasts and presents, and modes and politics of representation. And doubtless on more levels than this *Baltimore* clearly stages a very different kind of intervention into the museum and wider cultures of Baltimore than *Mining*. Yet several advantages remain in considering this art, its aims, and its realization in comparison. Although both projects were commissioned by The Contemporary Museum,⁴⁷ in discussing his work Julien pointedly expressed his view of the relationship between the host



3.11 Isaac Julien, *Baltimore*, 2003. Still: characters in street in linear perspective. Courtesy the artist and Metro Pictures.



3.12 Isaac Julien, *Baltimore*, 2003. Still: Melvin Van Peebles with his wax double. Courtesy the artist and Metro Pictures. ALSO PLATE 7.

institutions, their facilitation of his project, and the resulting work: “We should forget about that sort of framework . . . through my own interest I approached the Great Blacks in Wax Museum. It wasn’t the Walters, it wasn’t the Contemporary, it was me. The idea of putting wax models in the Walters [was] my idea.”⁴⁸ Julien’s resistance to programmatic implementations can, I think, be understood as a way of gaining some conceptual distance from Wilson’s project. More importantly, though, it underscores the creative and precisely counterinstitutional nature of the intercultural collaboration about which *Baltimore* fantasizes. The film’s derationalization of the city, its “characteristic” cultural spaces, even of the figure of the artistic subject (in tripling the figure of Van Peebles) works precisely to criticize the territorializing terms of such arrangements. Julien’s virtually empty city of the future-past demonstrates in another way how, as Kwon observes, the “siting of art in ‘real’ places can also be a means to extract the social and historical dimensions of these places in order to variously serve the thematic drive of the artist [and] satisfy institutional demographic profiles.”⁴⁹ The proliferation of types and relations among real places in *Baltimore* replaces a vital chunk of Baltimore experience with something different, and less.

Both artists approached Baltimore as a specific setting that plays host to a particularly old and extreme version of the American racial drama. Also, both works evoke and construct fantastic scenarios as devices with which to rearticulate existing representations of culture. Wilson deployed fantasy, or urged its use, in his critical reinstallation, off of which viewers could read his own readings of actually and subliminally manifested race relations in the Maryland Historical Society collection. But as I will argue below, Julien’s film uses fantasy to envision relations embedded in the fabric *connecting* the institutions but designated as impossible within them—including cinema and cultural politics, as well as the museum and state culture.





3.13 Isaac Julien, *Baltimore*, 2003. Van Peebles with Malcolm X and Martin Luther King Jr. *Baltimore Series: Déjà vu*, 2003. Three color photographs, 39¼ × 44 in. (left and right images), 39¼ × 49¼ in. (center image). Courtesy the artist and Metro Pictures. ALSO PLATE 8.

Julien uses *mise-en-scène*, sound, and side-by-side screen placement to push the sometimes clashing different ambiances of the four sites (three museums and the city itself) nearly to the point of synthesis but never to resolution. *Baltimore*'s viewer surrenders her sense of place early on. In the first minute, Julien displays the nondescript panoramic city view, downscales to a black neighborhood in montage, and follows the female protagonist into the wax museum. Inside, the interplay of gazes, unresolved points of view, and visual elisions suggest competing sovereignties, their transaction equally affecting the integrity of the institutional and human bodies that are perhaps the film's true "subjects." *Baltimore* first achieves this effect in the (visual) establishment of its setting as fragmented, dispersed, and intercultural. This issue arises in a second way with the appearance and disposition of its protagonists, both of whom embody multiple subject types.

Julien's image of Baltimore functions paradoxically but crucially in the film. *Baltimore* opens on a series of shots that present the city as it is territorialized by tropes. Seen in gloomy, overcast weather, it appears as a typical contemporary American scene of perpetual development, an urban center, a ghetto, an "ideal city" on the order of Renaissance representation, and as a nondescript matrix of streets, structures, and walls. These spare shots of the city successfully evoke a certain traffic in relations that we know to exist in cities without having to see it. This is the city that urban theorist Massimo Cacciari has called "the general form assumed by the process of the rationalization of social relations."⁵⁰ This city-as-"general form" serves as the literal support for the cultural institutions traversed by the film's action, whose fantastic quality is signaled by its almost colorized brightness in comparison to the bleakly toned cityscapes. *Baltimore* positions these sites, then, as highly visible efforts to capture and describe these processes in events of fabricated, summary representation. In this way *Baltimore* uses the weirdly rich deadness of

the urban scene as a way to establish a context at an inherent disjuncture from the pale idea of place promoted within the (any) museum's practice. By the force of irony, the institutions' static character is contravened by their dramatic overinvestment with color aura, which now appears the embalmed remainder of a metropolitan ambience stripped from the city. This effect animates *Baltimore's* images of the all-too-real city in reverse, making the opulent and (symbolically) thickly peopled museum spaces seem all the more airless and uninhabitable.

By accenting the hyperreal alienation that links the three institutions, this radical contextualization derationalizes the known relations of difference, distance, and estrangement between them. The film acknowledges but does not dwell on the obvious contrasts between its institutional sites, signifying them only by reference to the plain, painted-cinderblock facade of the Wax Museum, past which the characters move at the film's beginning and end, and by the showy opulence that the Peabody's and Walters' spaces have in common. Rather, *Baltimore* finds its meaning in "the *violation* of [the] signifying limit of *space*," which allows it to apply differential visions of the past, both specific to Baltimore and generalized, to create a matrix of contemporary intercultural relationships across space and time, reality and fantasy.⁵¹ Julien's contextualization of the film *in the city* and *Baltimore's* formal erasure of the boundaries between institutions rigorously rework "site" into a ground that makes thinkable connections between the constituencies the museums ostensibly "serve," rather than one that anchors communities in their specificity. *Baltimore* finds a viable craft for this strange mode of travel by dislodging the filmic convention of location, which Julien thematizes by *locating location*. That is, the museums are not only in and for Baltimore but come to be what they are according to the "complexity of the real" that obtains in that city. Each opens a space that might ask to be viewed as culturally specific, but cannot at

any rate refuse its dependency on the chain of proofs provided by other museums and libraries past and present. It can only circulate its particular account by simultaneously circulating those of others “unlike” it.

The representational possibilities opened up with the establishment of this moving ground are mirrored in *Baltimore*’s construction of subjectivity. Although the film’s capacious spaces contain conspicuously few living subjects, the dramatis personae are themselves subjects configured in multiplicity. What’s more, this multiplicity is *effective*: for the most part, *Baltimore* sees Van Peebles and Afro-Cyborg for how they define and alter our view of the spaces, rather than the other way around. In the scenes constructed to mimic the linear perspective of *The Ideal City*, the characters’ movements are emphatically away from the center that would vanish them (see fig. 3.11). They are at the same time impossible to quite get into focus as characters, since each is a hybrid whose various tropes never align neatly. The opening voiceover is a nostalgic aural collage of dialogue from blaxploitation films, but when the actors themselves appear, *Baltimore* commences its unraveling of the notion of the screen icon-cum-paradigmatic black subject. Van Peebles is introduced under the sign of blaxploitation but bears the worn look of a reluctant cultural icon. He moves with none of Sweetback’s purposiveness (Van Peebles’s protagonist was ever “on the run”) and appears particularly nonplused by the melodramatic appeals of the Great Blacks in Wax Museum. Importantly, neither Van Peebles nor the film can muster the untiring attention and vigilance that this sort of display would exact from the visitor; instead *Baltimore* finds a rather tedious and forced progression—and makes its tedium felt. We are invited to regard these disidentifications as prefiguring Van Peebles’s failure to find “himself” in *any* of the film’s venues. Both Van Peebles and Afro-Cyborg signify opaquely from start to finish, with Van Peebles symbolizing, at once, the antihero Sweetback and the revered director, myth and mythmaker. Likewise, Afro-Cyborg is

an amalgam of recognizable blaxploitation characters from the past and a specter of futurity: sorting her out as so many parts Coffy, Black Belt Jones, or Dawn is a futile affair, for she is all and none of these figures. The characters resist typology to the same degree that the spaces themselves do and in virtually the same way: first as spectacles and then as the blurry-edged sites of their undoing. That is, the characters are differently defined by different viewers, their movements through the film's spaces impacting upon both their own definition and those of the spaces themselves. In this way, *Baltimore* figures the struggle with visibility as a crisis of coherence, a conflict endured by and at the level of the subject but radiating subject-effects outward that alters the contexts through which subjects move, including those designed to convey their very meaning. *Baltimore* deems this struggle a productive condition that undermines the very ground of institutionally fixed relation, leaving unresolved the tension among its locations to assure the open-endedness of its subjects. A persistent troubling of identity categories, one that begins with the subject but also exceeds it, lies at the foundation of *Baltimore's* institutional critique.

As the film progresses, one realizes that much of the "action" is thwarted or unseen, consisting of our construction of fantastical arrangements of site and subjectivity. This activity is unavoidable, for not only is this how film is made to be assimilated by spectators, but the self-compounding implications of the diegesis are so great as to produce the need for a reading that contains them. But while *Baltimore* is certainly a viewer-identified rather than meaning-identified film work, this characteristic is, arguably, essential to the film's dissipation of the narratives its characters and locations want so desperately to tell. The film thrives on this proliferation, may even be said to espouse it as a practice: further elaboration as a strategy for preventing showing and telling from congealing into show-and-tell. A committed mobility among spaces and

types that foils the stoppage of cultural time and space in museum-friendly forms: this, *Baltimore* insists, is the fantasy we surrender in viewing such institutions only in their discreteness. Because identity is such a form, what may seem a contrast between the Walters Art Museum and the Great Blacks in Wax Museum is actually a commonality. Both “preserve culture” through a kind of provenance that authenticates identity and isolates histories, establishing chains of ownership between their holdings and those who, following the accepted protocols of use, would recognize them as their own. But *Baltimore*, in founding its characters in multiplicity and disidentification, finds these institutions’ images of culture as they are caught up in an almost arbitrary system of exchanges where the really determinant forces are users and their means of usage. The sites are neither depicted nor capable of being read as somehow essentializing in themselves. Rather, they provide the protagonists with a context for identification, transfixing delight, existential crisis, and plain bewilderment. With the migration of the Wax Museum statues to the Walters, *Baltimore* makes concrete what the film accomplishes from the start: a displacement of objects from their “proper places,” a move that makes imaginable an opening of museum frameworks themselves. This view, not only available in fantasy but consequent upon “the act of the practice of thinking,” erases both the traditional division between the museum’s physical setting and its defining, human context and its suspension of time in neat series of representational moments.

But what is the fruit of all this work I am imputing to *Baltimore*’s reconceptualization of the “cultural framework”? I want to suggest that it is a view of the kinds of existence that such frameworks disallow, which only become possible through the vigilant practice of exit and return. By deploying symbols of blaxploitation, which worked hard to be an independent cultural form, Julien underlines the powers and exclu-

sions operating in more general practices of heroization and memorialization—matters of *existence* to the degree that they are foremost matters of subjectivity and history. Importantly, once we see Van Peebles enter the Wax Museum during the film, the only other time he appears there he is leaving, walking away without noticeable reaction to the “Slave Ship Experience,” which has been described as a “galley of scenes depicting rape, torture, forced feeding, and other such atrocities as throwing the sick or enfeebled slaves overboard into the mouths of attentive sharks, all the while a chorus of reverbed voices whispering ‘Remember, remember!’”⁵² Julien’s decision to distance Van Peebles from the Great Blacks in Wax Museum in this way—he declines it, only to be enjoined by it later, as an effigy—is perhaps *Baltimore*’s most direct statement about the processes that establish cultural icons and iconographies as versions of social truth.

A filmic genre that responded directly to a structural tension over questions of representation within black culture *about* black culture, blaxploitation offered an alternative to the closure of the black political imagination threatened by a two-party choice between nationalism and Civil Rights. It accomplished its political critique in part by pushing the boundaries of black sexuality, compromising hegemonical priorities with felicitous recourse to interracial sex and the inversion (or at least playful manipulation) of gender roles. The mainstream cinema, blaxploitation pointed out, did politics too, by failing to offer alternatives to stagnating political options. By thematizing the cinema within its museum fantasy, *Baltimore* reminds us that the cinema is an institution of art like any other. Like the museum, the cinema leverages spectators’ relationships to cultural formations of desire, including fantasy. Though the two mediums are configured, occupied, and taken up differently, both are symptomatic of that style of cultivated knowledge about the world which is peculiar to modernity. For Foucault, the library and the

museum were exemplary cases, both managing the subject's relationship to fantasy by channeling it into a mode of study. Even the decorum we observe in these spaces, Foucault suggests, constitutes an acknowledgment of their supremacy within a hierarchy of reveries: "Fantasies are carefully deployed in the hushed library. . . . The fantastic is no longer a property of the heart, nor is it found among the incongruities of nature; it evolves from the accuracy of knowledge." Upon their institutionalization, the domain of fantasy was "no longer the night, the sleep of reason, or the uncertain void that stands before desire, but, on the contrary, wakefulness, untiring attention, zealous erudition, and constant vigilance. Henceforth, the visionary experience [arose] from the black and white surface of printed signs."⁵³

Like these, cinema is an institution that designates certain practices of creation, narration, and existence as venerable and worthy of emulation while proscribing others through hierarchization and exclusion. Indeed it accomplishes this with a relative lack of encumbrance by narrative immediacy. *Baltimore*, in its critical appropriation of blaxploitation, affiliates itself with a cinematic practice that was pitched against mainstream cinema's seemingly complete annexation by what was, for many, an unacceptably abstract style of imagining the new phase of politics that had seemed to open up around 1970. Thus blaxploitation was significant for Julien not only in its medium specificity but in its proximity to his own method. *Baltimore* bears several marks of the optimistic, critical history of the present that Julien has elaborated over several of the films he has created since the mid 1980s. This enterprise developed as part of a larger elaboration of queer cultural practice in which Julien is a frontline participant. As Michael Warner has put it, because "[q]ueers do a kind of practical social reflection just in finding ways of being queer," questions of subjectivity and desire are located squarely in the center of the critical consideration of *how one finds one's*

way to sexual, racial, political, and other social identifications, as a subject whose very possibility is denied in normative frameworks. For the far from simple reason that “the logic of the sexual order [in which homosexuality is pathologized or altogether vanished] is so deeply embedded by now in an indescribably wide range of social institutions, and is embedded in the most standard accounts of the world, queer struggles aim not just at toleration or equal status but at challenging those institutions and accounts.”⁵⁴

Here, Julien suggests how his queer investment informed *Looking for Langston*, his landmark film of 1989 that brought him to an international audience:

I wanted to talk about the role of the black artist in relationship to the black community and specifically the role of the black gay artist. . . . So if you happened to be gay during the Harlem Renaissance, what kinds of spaces would you have existed in? I wasn’t particularly interested in celebrating his own specific lifestyle. I was trying to comment on how I imagined this lifestyle would have existed.⁵⁵

Julien avows the “role” of the black artist as something to be problematized from the standpoint of desire, specifically the gay male desire widely suppressed in black life. But importantly, Julien does this not to locate equivalencies or models, but rather to ground present-day fantasies by locating, or claiming, points of identification in the past. Hence the centrality of fantasy: to ask, “If you happened to be gay during the Harlem Renaissance, what kinds of spaces would you have existed in?” is, paraphrasing Hall, to bring to light relationships and structures that cannot be visible—and very possibly did not have the luxury of inhabiting spaces as such. Like Wilson’s *Mining the Museum*, Julien’s *Looking*

for *Langston* also satisfied a desire to achieve visibility in history. But Julien gave the audience a purchase on the film's subject and relationships by making "desire exist in the construction of images and [creating] a narrative that would enable audiences to think, rather than be told." As Julien says, "I was trying to comment on how I imagined." Again, Cowie's account of fantasy is useful here: "In analyzing fantasy, it is not a criterion that there be any factual basis for the fantasy 'in reality' or that there be a wish for it to 'really happen,' rather the criterion is the level of 'reality' the fantasy has for and in the psychical system for the subject."⁵⁶ Foregrounding fantasy, and thus refusing the culturally clarifying role traditionally assigned to black artists, made it possible for Julien to imagine and then to recreate Hughes and the Harlem Renaissance on his own terms, as well as, more importantly, to emphasize the contradictory experiences in which nonconformist desires, such as homosexual and interracial desire, do not just implicate but impact the structuring of blackness and black representational spaces.

Accordingly, the materials of fantasization in *Baltimore* are the institutions, the city itself, and the notional black community. The film recognizes in each a limiting idealization of black social life which risks compartmentalizing time, dictating identifications, directing political imagination, and stopping cultural flows whether institutionalized in a fact, an answer to, or an example of "conditions." *Baltimore* itself proposes rethinking these formations in terms of relationships and structures that are invisible yet implicit among them. If viewing the film amounts to a crisis of situation (re: place, history, fact), this is because *Baltimore* understands this movement as effective, as productive of a new kind of situation—one that is above all representable. Within the film, the spaces are indistinct: the characters enter only one institution (the Wax Museum), but in doing so, they gain seemingly unfettered ac-

cess to all three; although Afro-Cyborg dials into her palm to make Van Peebles materialize in the Peabody stack room, the two never meet face to face, and she never enters the Walters painting gallery. As if to escape the resolutions held out by plot or the designation of aesthetic personality, Afro-Cyborg and Van Peebles dissolve the spaces they occupy, such that *Baltimore's* setting-subject relationship is one of interdependence instead of determination. Vitally, the characters don't accomplish this by special exertion: there is no drama of escape, and the chase is unconsummated (so much so that one feels as though Julien lost interest in it). What matters is keeping moving. What viewers might consider the protagonists' failure to materialize fully against backgrounds, real and imagined, that would clarify them by location in a "proper" place, the characters seem to experience as a banal fact of life.

Baltimore's refusal to submit its characterization, action, or setting to the determining logics of location seems to reveal something about the principle of those locations' selection, or at least the import of these characters and the creative tropes they represent. An observation by Joanna Russ about the aesthetics of science fiction well describes the relation of subject and site in *Baltimore*: "The relation of foreground and background that we are used to after a century and a half of realism will not obtain. Indeed they may be reversed.... Stories ostensibly about persons will really be about topology. Erotics will be intercranial, mechanical (literally), and moving."⁵⁷ Afro-futurism, which is underwritten in part by the logic of continuous transformation, is an aesthetics of interdependence as a form of survival. But just as surely as Afro-Cyborg evokes an Octavia Butler character, when she hides a pistol in her afro she calls to mind Coffy, the blaxploitation heroine played by Pam Grier, who stowed razor blades in hers. The uncertainty characteristic of a life lived exceeding one's categories seems to inform the characters' idea

of a “proper place.” That it is guaranteed by these insurgent black cultural politics seems to indicate their importance for *Baltimore*’s explosion of the cultural framework epitomized by the museum, and in this instance especially by its aversion to the popular.

It bears noting that both blaxploitation and Afro-futurism date to the 1970s, falling therefore outside the bounds of the Great Blacks in Wax Museum’s political narrative. As Mark Alice Durant writes, even though the museum was founded in 1980, the “culturally enshrined heroism of the Civil Rights Movement provides the culminating iconography.”⁵⁸ This periodization appears symptomatic of the same positivism that sets Elijah Muhammad and Malcom X, or, as we see in *Baltimore*, Kweisi Mfume and Louis Farrakhan, side by side in its wax dioramas. For blaxploitation, it also produces a historical quandary correspondent to the political and cultural position it occupied when first coming to public notice, in 1971, with the controversy over Van Peebles’s film. But within the history of black cultural practice, *Sweet Sweetback’s Baadasssss Song* represents a powerfully articulated ambivalence—as Van Peebles himself put it, “the colored intelligentsia were not too happy about it; neither were the nationalists”⁵⁹—as an art form that was literally caught between politics and pleasure in attempting to respond to the constrictions of both black and nonblack demarcations of black representational space. Though, as Ed Guerrero reminds us, *Sweet Sweetback* was “made at the height of the male-dominated Black Power rebellion and . . . marks a turning point for the black male image on the big screen,”⁶⁰ this turning point did not entail a decisive reconsolidation of black roles and identities. Instead, it refused stale, box-office-friendly portrayals of “noble Negroes” identified with Hollywood as well as normative conceptions of race, sexuality, and gender identities upheld in dominant models of black politics.⁶¹ The film’s aesthetic is one of unbroken movement between contradictory domains: across antagonisms

between black men and women largely disavowed in public life to that point; across racial lines, both in experimentations with the political gains of preceding decades and in open acknowledgment of interracial desire (in one of *Sweet Sweetback's* most notorious scenes, the title character and a white woman have sex before a mixed-race crowd of on-lookers); and across—indeed, in opposition to—conventional models of black masculinity promoted in previous filmmaking and in the standardized roster of racial “role models.” As increasingly distant yet ever more needful reminders of a politics of representation centered on pleasures forbidden by the cultural authorities and committed to envisioning a thriving social and political future by no means guaranteed in reality, blaxploitation and Afro-futurism provide *Baltimore* with a crucial energy for restoring existence’s constitutive antagonisms to “black representation.”

Just as importantly, within *Baltimore*, blaxploitation, like Afro-futurism but to a greater degree owing to Van Peebles’s iconicity, denotes the tactic of resymbolization itself as a way to make new culture. Specifically, as simultaneously a medium-specific device with which to complicate the “identity” of Julien’s film and a complex sign of the unfinished business of imagining culture differently, blaxploitation is a tool for prying apart a viewpoint on contemporary social arrangements that neatly aligns subjectivity, artistic personality, culture, and community—and is typified by the museum. (At this moment it may be helpful to note the fear of fantasy at work in Du Bois’s 1926 proscription, which declared that Negro art would not abide “the mere stylist or dilettante.”) Other examples of Julien’s film practice allow insight into the institution’s significance for him. So, too, do the prose and poetry of Essex Hemphill, who collaborated with Julien on several projects before his death in 1995.⁶² Julien’s *Vagabondia* (1999) centers on a vagabond dancer who, with the ghosts of two Creole women, stages an occupation of

Sir John Soane's Museum, which occupies the architect's London house. *The Attendant* (1993), developed in response to an Orientalist painting of slaves on the western coast of Africa by François-Auguste Biard, re-fashions the dominations enacted in the background of the painting into an affirmation of gay interracial desire in the historical foreground, now depicted in fantasy sequences of sado-masochism enacted and directed by an after-hours museum guard. In both of these films, as in *Baltimore*, museums become the site of processes that seem incongruous with the priorities and world pictures established by their holdings, yet are exactly what mark them as sites where meaningful cultural actions continually occur. They represent the museum as always at work: on the work, on the artist, on the viewer, even on incidental passers-through. Julien's museum, then, renders transparent the force with which wider, museumizing trends enforce silence in regard to actual sexual and other social practices: "The point is that the *exclusion* necessary to the formation of social identity . . . is simultaneously a *production* at the level of the Imaginary, and a production . . . of a complex hybrid fantasy emerging out of the very attempt to demarcate boundaries, to unite and purify the social collectivity."⁶³ Since domination is achieved partly through this type of production, its refusal can be carried out in counterfantasies that open boundaries, upsetting identity's regulatory function. *Baltimore* generates just such a disturbance, a fantasy within a fantasy using living elements—Afro-Cyborg and Van Peebles—signifying past and present to lever open the museum's time. This process unfreezes the subject deadened, and the processes annulled, under the museum's gaze; in Lacan's words:

This terminal time of the gaze, which completes the gesture [distinguished from the act], I place strictly in relation to what I later say about the evil eye. The gaze in itself not only terminates the

movement, it freezes it. . . . [T]he evil eye is the *fascinum*, it is that which has the effect of arresting movement and, literally, of killing life. At the moment the subject stops, suspending his gesture, he is mortified. The anti-life, anti-movement function of this terminal point is the *fascinum*, and it is precisely one of the dimensions in which the power of the gaze is exercised directly.⁶⁴

The museumizing gesture is a threat exactly because it reproduces cultural subjects as frozen—a function made apparent by the disconcerting effigies that fill the wax museum, but dramatically more reversed when they reconvene at the Walters. Its stilling eye harnesses the “fascinating” power of the picture, object, or culturally specific institution to fix culture by fixing the world of subjects to whom it reveals itself in turn, and whom it can thereby be said to “represent.” This process also invests the subject of culture with the power to contemplate others while renouncing involvement with them. In a 1972 denouncement of blaxploitation, Roy Innis, the national director of the Congress on Racial Equality (CORE), conveyed this sentiment in a defense of racial realism: “Once you get through that vicarious thrill of seeing a black man beat up a white man on the screen [in a blaxploitation film], you go back and face the same evil system you faced before you went there. And we should *always* deal with reality and not fantasy.”⁶⁵ But such concerted efforts to clarify the categories of culture—racial, artistic, representational—are precisely what made disorienting projections such as those of Afro-futurism and blaxploitation necessary. In blaxploitation, as in Julien’s film, the recourse to fantasy is valued precisely for its power to dismantle the seemingly limitless power of the museumist model of cultural representation epitomized in Innis’s remarks, to perpetuate an ethical standard of representation that sees subjects and cultures not as they are constituted through actual social practices, but rather as they

are arrested *by* the “evil eye” or “system” whose very mode is that of contemplative stillness and silence.

Structurally, *Baltimore* turns away from this model by distributing the single film image across a horizon of dislocation, dispersed in three units across the viewer’s field of vision. The stand-alone film image is already keyed to movement rather than arrest. But when divided into three unsynched channels, the film construct counteracts the production of a straight mirror image. This continual re-fusing of the image and postponement of narrative satisfaction exactly opposes the kind of vision peculiar to the museum. Indeed, *Baltimore* makes some of its most ambitious visual claims in the service of stretching the contracted sense of time that plagues the museum’s viewpoint on culture. Just as its triptych construction stresses the processual quality of the film image, literally its persistence through time, it also lends *Baltimore* at times the quality of an altarpiece. This is especially so when Julien steeps Van Peebles in the Walters Museum’s grandiloquent, oil-painting-lined architecture. The effect is most pronounced at the end of the film, when, after a sequence of face-offs between Van Peebles and his wax double (in which the pair are backed by a devotional painting), Julien fixes the camera on Van Peebles’s wax effigy and slowly begins to retreat until the wax Van Peebles is seen to stand between Malcolm X and Martin Luther King Jr.—here representing the opposed forces that united in their attack on blaxploitation’s “distortion of the race life-style.”⁶⁶ This fantasy construction of black cultural history (Julien had Van Peebles’s likeness created for the film) not only memorializes Van Peebles but grants him a mediating role between two resolute, and irreconcilable, figures of cultural politics. Yet in the same move with which Julien appears to apotheosize the director, he underlines the threat this museumizing closure poses. The final scene in the Walters has the real Van Peebles (with cigar) address the wax triumvirate from the two outer screens, shortly before

exiting the wax museum (not the Walters) and returning Julien's camera to the street. When Van Peebles meets his wax doppelganger, Julien evokes but does not use a common narrative device, known from *La beauté du diable*, in which Faust's mirror image begins to live a life of its own, and from films in which a protagonist's reflection exits the mirror to do deeds in the subject's name.⁶⁷ *Baltimore* short-circuits this device's duplicity, using it instead to affirm Van Peebles's entitlement to be simultaneously an icon of good or ill *and* incongruous with his own image.

Van Peebles has said of blaxploitation that it changed Hollywood film by adding the formula "of the black winning and being triumphant."⁶⁸ Doubtless its status at *Baltimore's* close is far less decisive, however. There it occupies the middle ground in a tripartite image of black political styles, wherein each unit represents a program of limited success. If *Baltimore* as a whole privileges Van Peebles, this is partly to do with artistic debt, but more so with his ability to signify the courage to commit representation to a radically expanded definition of "community," as founded in uneven sexual relations, practical indulgences in proscribed entertainments, and an ultimately unpredictable relationship to racial others. Thus when, toward the end of *Baltimore*, several statues from Great Blacks in Wax gather in the baroque paintings gallery of the Walters, rather than sharpening the differences between these two classes of objects, Julien films them in soft focus and in an arrangement that causes them to appear "woven into a single tableau with the paintings."⁶⁹ This scene appends an ellipsis, not a period, on *Baltimore's* fantastical exercise in culture reformation—an exercise that posits cultural identity not as defined by an engagement with cultural objects but as emerging from it, that understands belonging as an active process rather than a given state.⁷⁰ Rather than puzzling over belonging as a problem in need of clarifying, *Baltimore* represents it as the organizing problem of living. Kobena Mercer has named this quandary "the challenge of

sameness: the fact that we share the same planet as our enemies and our adversaries.”⁷¹ To make a black man visiting a fancy white art museum into a spectacle as *Baltimore* does, though not in the way *Mining the Museum* had, is not simply to ask what makes that a spectacle, but to attempt against the odds to compose an *unfascinating* image of the practice of solidarity. Blaxploitation, now, can be seen as doing the same. For instance, when *Sweet Sweetback*’s politicized fantasy in direct opposition to a very old silence on some blacks’ actual social practices—indulgences in sex, drugs, style, even stereotypes—it disarticulated race-identified cultural spaces within and beyond cinema, posing the question of culture itself as a function of containment.

This suspicious view of frameworks of culture where the creation of lives is a central occupation has long been an informing idea for the practice of British cultural studies, and, with a few notable exceptions, a missing one in American-style considerations of minority representational activities. Many cultural studies practitioners have since the 1960s worked from a cognizance of a British “version” of the very problematic explored in *Mining the Museum*—namely, that black Britons are a “reminder and remainder of [Britain’s] historical past, and of the paradoxical disadvantage of an early start as one of the key factors of present-day, post-Empire, decline: *we are here because you were there*.”⁷² Emerging from the crisis of representational authority incited by these “reminders” were coalitions that bound diversely affiliated black Britons to other cultural and political minorities in cultures of hybridity which, as Mercer reminds us, “must be seen as crucial efforts to answer the ‘possibility and necessity of creating a new culture’: *so that you can live*.”⁷³ Within these provisional formations, representation is conceived as a matter of establishing conditions for survival within, not against, an idiom dominated (*but not belonging*) to one’s adversaries. Sometimes, survival conditions require one to turn a critical eye on “one’s own” without being

seen to abandon a shared interest. In this respect, Julien and Mercer, as practitioners of cultural studies and sometime collaborators, have played vital roles. Their work and that which it has inspired begins by problematizing a racial realism that presumes the authority, authenticity, and transparency of straight black masculinities. Still more importantly it has used the open grid of “black sexuality” to multiply the kinds of relationship available in “reality” by dialoguing openly with the limitless possibilities opened up in fantasy, which lie between the social and the psychic.

In enacting a related move, *Baltimore* complicates our thinking not just about *Mining the Museum* but about a matrix of relations between cultural conditions and consciousness. Its avowals are manipulated and uneasy, but its resolve to outrun fixed relations and politics of representation is quite certain. The cadre of personages gathered in its closing tableau—Peter Paul Rubens, W.E. B. Du Bois, Billie Holliday, El Greco, and Melvin Van Peebles are there—is important exactly because it is so unlikely. Yet how swiftly it puts into one’s mind the kind of price we pay for mercilessly clean pictures of culture.

Critical Reader (Westport: Praeger, 2004), 116–132; Bakhtin's emphases. For Bakhtin, the satirical form is exemplified by Menippean satire such as the *Apocolocyntosis* by Seneca, and the *Satyricon*, whose author is known, interestingly for our purposes, as Petronius Arbiter. These works are often published together. See Petronius Arbiter, *The Satyricon of Petronius and the Apocolocyntosis of Seneca*, trans. J. P. Sullivan (New York: Penguin Books, 1986).

84. Jacques Derrida, *Aporias*, trans. Thomas Dutoit (Stanford: Stanford University Press, 1993), 12.

3 FANTASIAS OF THE MUSEUM

1. Fred Wilson, quoted in Donald Garfield, "Making the Museum Mine: An Interview with Fred Wilson," *Museum News* (May-June 1993): 48.

2. James Clifford, *The Predicament of Culture: Twentieth-Century Ethnography, Literature, and Art* (Cambridge: Harvard University Press, 1988).

3. Wilson, quoted in Garfield, "Making the Museum Mine," 48.

4. This aspect of Wilson's early museology draws it into close proximity with Foucault's conception of genealogy: "And this is what I would call genealogy, that is, a form of history which can account for the *constitution* of knowledges, discourses, domains of objects, etc., without having to make reference to a subject which is either transcendental in relation to the fields of events or runs in its empty sameness throughout the course of history." Michel Foucault, "Truth and Power," in *The Foucault Reader*, ed. Paul Rabinow (New York: Pantheon, 1984), 59. My emphasis.

5. *Rooms with a View* ran for nearly two months at the Bronx Council on the Arts' Longwood Arts Gallery.

6. This is Bhabha's characterization of the voice of early modernist colonial literature. See Homi Bhabha, "Articulating the Archaic," in his *The Location of Culture* (London: Routledge, 1994), 123.

7. Lois Nesbitt, "Fred Wilson at Metro Pictures," *Artforum International* 31 (November 1992): 105.

8. Fred Wilson, quoted in David Kellerman, "Fred Wilson at Metro Pictures," *Flash Art* 167 (November-December 1992): 98.

9. Wilson's work in this mode was largely suspended following the 1992 commission from the Baltimore Historical Society to reinstall its third-floor galleries, which led first to *Mining the Museum* and subsequently to Wilson's being constantly sought after by numerous museums around the world to serve as a resident artist.

10. See Fred Wilson, *The Museum: Mixed Metaphors* by Fred Wilson, exh. cat. (Seattle: Seattle Art Museum, 1993).
11. For an excellent survey of Wilson's practice, see Maurice Berger, *Fred Wilson: Objects and Installations 1979–2000* (Baltimore: Center for Art and Visual Culture, University of Maryland Baltimore County, 2001). Elsewhere I have argued that aspects of Wilson's fabricated museums better accommodate the project of radical intervention than do his actual interventions. The latter works have attracted the bulk of attention, but in my view this is to the detriment of the "off-site" installations in which Wilson fashions hypothetical museum spaces. This work is important for me because of the intelligence and power of Wilson's suggestions about how the museum might be resited—practically by him, imaginatively by its publics—to fashion a more accurate historical picture of difference's eruption into fundamentally homogeneous frameworks. See "Institutionalizing the Postcolonial," in Darby English, "Black Artists, Black Work? Regarding Difference in Three Dimensions," Ph.D. diss., University of Rochester, 2002.
12. See *The Decade Show: Frameworks of Identity in the 1980s*, exh. cat. (New York: Museum of Contemporary Hispanic Art, New Museum of Contemporary Art, and Studio Museum of Harlem, 1990), and Jeanne Canizzo, ed., *Into the Heart of Africa* (Toronto: Royal Ontario Museum, 1989).
13. An example is Lothar Baumgarten's *Unsettled Objects*, a series of slide projections compiled during an extensive photo-essaying of European ethnographic museums that Baumgarten conducted from 1968 to 1970. See *The Museum as Muse: Artists Reflect*, exh. cat. (New York: Museum of Modern Art, 2000).
14. For an excellent survey of projects relevant to the prehistory of *Mining the Museum*, see Lisa G. Corrin, "Mining the Museum: Artists Look at Museums, Museums Look at Themselves," in Lisa G. Corrin, ed., *Mining the Museum*, exh. cat. (Baltimore: Maryland Historical Society, 1994), 1–22.
15. Andrea Fraser, "An Artist's Statement," in *Place Position Presentation Public*, ed. Ine Gevers (Amsterdam: De Balie, 1998), 70.
16. See Douglas Crimp, *On the Museum's Ruins* (Cambridge: MIT Press, 1994). For a discussion of the role of the museum's discourse as a function of modernity's project, see Donald Preziosi, "Museology and Museography," *Art Bulletin* 77 (March 1995): 13–15.
17. For a discussion of this distinction, see Joan W. Scott, "The Evidence of Experience," in James Chandler, Arnold Davidson, and Harry Harootun-

ian, eds., *Questions of Evidence* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1991), esp. 368–380.

18. Crimp, “The Art of Exhibition,” in *On the Museum’s Ruins*, 249–250.

19. Fuchs, quoted in Crimp, “The Art of Exhibition,” 249.

20. On this subject, see Tony Bennett, *The Birth of the Museum: History, Theory, Politics* (New York: Routledge, 1995); Benedict Anderson, *Imagined Communities* (London: Verso, 1984), esp. ch. 4; and Bennett, *Pasts beyond Memory: Evolution, Museums, Colonialism* (New York: Routledge, 2004).

21. For several excellent studies that contextualize this problem, see Rosalyn Deutsche, *Evictions: Art and Spatial Politics* (Cambridge: MIT Press, 1996), and Miwon Kwon, *One Place after Another: Site-Specific Art and Locational Identity* (Cambridge: MIT Press, 2002), esp. chs. 2 and 5, important discussions of the functions of place in site-specific projects, in which *Mining the Museum* is briefly discussed.

22. Kwon, *One Place*, 147.

23. I will speak critically of Wilson’s installation here but, as an advocate of Wilson’s work, I feel that I should explain why I have found it necessary to do so. Until a comparably ambitious project challenges *Mining the Museum*, this approach makes sense for at least two reasons. First, because in dissertations, articles, textbooks, exhibition schedules, and museum boardrooms, *Mining the Museum* continues to stand as a benchmark for “black interventions” into the relations and politics of representation. And precisely as a benchmark, it risks forestalling the very work of perspectivizing “black experience” that is most needed to dismantle regimes of exemplarity. Second, because it generated a tension worth dwelling on, in offering little to no account of relational shifts between the past it surveyed and the present it occupied. In this way it *becomes* the history that it would claim to complicate. It is precisely because for so many *Mining* is a fixed, generative image in the iconography of multiculturalism in an increasingly internationalized art world that this deservedly illustrious project continues to warrant considerate debate, not just ceremonial invocation. As critical historians, it cannot suffice for us to congratulate the work for *starting* something; we must remain intent on expanding the project it may have inaugurated, on making noise about the limits it may inadvertently impose on our imagination of creative institutional change.

24. Lisa G. Corrin, “*Mining the Museum*: An Installation Confronting History,” *Curator* 36 (December 1993): 302–331.

25. Fred Wilson, quoted in Leslie King-Hammond, "A Conversation with Fred Wilson," in Corrin, ed., *Mining the Museum*, 34, 32.
26. George Ciscle and Charles Lyle, foreword to Corrin, ed., *Mining the Museum*, lxxi.
27. Wilson, quoted in King-Hammond, "A Conversation," 33.
28. Ibid.
29. We are aided in our analysis by the excellent volume edited by Lisa Corrin that appeared in 1994, the year after *Mining* closed. In addition to containing a detailed photo record of the installation, the catalogue compiles texts that introduce the Maryland Historical Society, historicize the practice of institutional critique, recount the docents' experiences guiding tours of the installation, and even reproduce a number of handwritten audience response sheets. At the same time, it remains important to maintain some critical distance from the catalogue's documentary claims.
30. Corrin, "*Mining the Museum: Artists Look at Museums*," 13.
31. Ibid.
32. Jackson and Clay were the nominated candidates at the first presidential nominating convention, held in Baltimore in 1832.
33. Of these, one of the more discomfiting was Wilson's nod to his Native American heritage in a display ironically titled "Portraits of Cigar Store Owners." The title referred to the elision of stereotyped and actually existing Native Americans, which the display exposed by juxtaposing a quintet of wooden "cigar store Indians" arrayed to face a wall of documentary photographs and snapshots of working-class Native Americans.
34. See Edward J. Hagerty, *Collis' Zouaves: The 114th Pennsylvania Volunteers in the Civil War* (Baton Rouge: Louisiana State University Press, 1997).
35. Corrin, "*Mining the Museum: Artists Look at Museums*," 18.
36. Ira Berlin, "*Mining the Museum* and the Rethinking of Maryland's History," in Corrin, ed., *Mining the Museum*, 45.
37. Kwon, *One Place*, 7.
38. Stuart Hall, "Cultural Studies: Two Paradigms," in *What Is Cultural Studies?* (New York: Oxford University Press, 1996), 41.
39. For an important discussion of this theme as a practical guideline for "writing the history of differences," see Scott, "Evidence of Experience," 381.
40. Hall, "Cultural Studies," 43.
41. Elizabeth Cowie, "Fantasia," in Jessica Evans and Stuart Hall, eds., *Visual Culture: The Reader* (London: Sage and the Open University, 1999), 356–358.

42. Kwon, *One Place*, 146.
43. Cowie, "Fantasia," 366.
44. The work shares a title with a series of twenty-nine 49-by-40-inch digital prints made from photographs Julien took during and after the filming and later issued in editions of 16.
45. Isaac Julien, quoted in Domenick Ammirati, "My Pop: Isaac Julien," *Artforum* (October 2004): 110.
46. Joanne Martin (cofounder of the Great Blacks in Wax Museum), quoted in Ginger Williams, "Great Blacks in Wax Museum Expansion Underway," *New York Amsterdam News* 93:52 (26 December 2002).
47. The Contemporary teamed up with the Walters for *Baltimore*, which represents one instance in an interinstitutional series called "Facing Museums."
48. Isaac Julien, quoted in Eric Allen Hatch, "Wax in the House," *Baltimore City Paper*, 2 June 2004. For an account of the project's beginnings, see Elissa Auther and Adam Lerner, "The Political Aesthetics of Isaac Julien's *Baltimore*," unpublished typescript, 2006, 35n.24.
49. Kwon, *One Place*, 53.
50. Massimo Cacciari, quoted in Patrizia Lombardo, *Cities, Words, and Images* (New York: Palgrave, 2003), 115–116.
51. Roland Barthes, quoted in Homi K. Bhabha, "Interrogating Identity," in *The Location of Culture*, 60; emphasis added.
52. Mark Alice Durant, "The Great Blacks in Wax Museum, Baltimore MD," *Art US* 5/6 (January/February 2005): 54.
53. Michel Foucault, "Fantasia of the Library," in *Language, Counter-Memory, Practice*, ed. Donald F. Bouchard, trans. Donald F. Bouchard and Sherry Simon (Ithaca: Cornell University Press, 1977), 90.
54. Michael Warner, introduction to Michael Warner, ed., *Fear of a Queer Planet: Queer Politics and Social Theory* (Minneapolis: University of Minnesota Press, 1993), xiii.
55. Isaac Julien, interviewed by Essex Hemphill, "Looking for Langston: An Interview with Isaac Julien," in Hemphill, *Brother to Brother: New Writings by Black Gay Men* (Boston: Alyson, 1989), 175–176, 180.
56. Cowie, "Fantasia," 358.
57. Joanna Russ, "Towards an Aesthetic of Science Fiction," *Science Fiction Studies* 6:2 (July 1975): 2. Reprinted in Russ, *To Write Like a Woman: Essays in Feminism and Science Fiction* (Bloomington: Indiana University Press, 1994).
58. Durant, "Great Blacks in Wax Museum," 55.

59. Melvin Van Peebles, quoted in Isaac Julien, director, *Baadasssss Cinema: A Bold Look at 70's Blaxploitation Films*, videorecording (New York: Docurama, 2002).
60. Ed Guerrero, "The Black Man on Our Screens and the Empty Space in Representation," in Thelma Golden, ed., *Black Male: Representations of Masculinity in Contemporary American Art* (New York: Whitney Museum of American Art and Abrams, 1994), 188.
61. On this subject, see Philip Brian Harper, *Are We Not Men? Masculine Anxiety and the Problem of African-American Identity* (New York: Oxford University Press, 1996), esp. ch. 2. For a contemporary response rooted in these concerns, see Lerone Bennett Jr., "The Emancipation Orgasm," *Ebony* 26 (September 1971): 106–116.
62. See especially "Visiting Hours," "Heavy Breathing," and "Notes," in Essex Hemphill, *Ceremonies: Prose and Poetry* (Philadelphia: Cleis, 1992).
63. Peter Stallybrass and Allon White, quoted in Stuart Hall, "For Allon White: Metaphors of Transformation," in David Morley and Kuan-Hsing Chen, eds., *Stuart Hall: Critical Dialogues in Cultural Studies* (London: Routledge, 1996), 303. Hall's emphases.
64. Jacques Lacan, *The Four Fundamental Principles of Psychoanalysis*, ed. Jacques-Alain Miller, trans. Alan Sheridan (London: Hogarth and the Institute of Psycho-Analysis, 1977), 117–118.
65. Roy Innis, quoted in Julien, *Baadasssss Cinema*. Innis's emphasis.
66. This statement is taken from a newspaper headline that appears in Julien, *Baadasssss Cinema*.
67. Stan Douglas, whose films Julien claims as generative for him, has employed these devices in a number of films. They are discussed in Bérénice Reynaud, "Stan Douglas's 'Win, Place, or Show,'" in Lynne Cooke and Karen Kelly, with Bettina Funcke, eds., *Robert Lehman Lectures on Contemporary Art*, no. 3 (New York: Dia Art Foundation, 2004), 128.
68. Melvin Van Peebles, quoted in Ed Guerrero, *Framing Blackness: The African-American Image in Film* (Philadelphia: Temple University Press, 1993), 91.
69. Auther and Lerner, "Political Aesthetics," 14.
70. On this function of belonging, see Neil Leach, "Belonging," *AA Files* 49 (Spring 2003), 76–82.
71. Kobena Mercer, "Black Art and the Burden of Representation," in *Welcome to the Jungle: New Positions in Black Cultural Studies* (London: Routledge, 1994), 256.

72. Ibid., 7; emphasis in original.

73. Ibid., 4; emphasis in original.

4 PAINTING PROBLEMS: GLENN LIGON'S POSTMODERNISM

Parts of this chapter appeared in earlier form in my "Glenn Ligon: Committed to Difficulty," in Wayne Baerwaldt and Thelma Golden, eds., *Glenn Ligon: Some Changes*, exh. cat. (Toronto: Power Plan Contemporary Art Gallery, 2005), 31–77.

1. Glenn Ligon, quoted in Byron Kim, "Interview with Glenn Ligon," in Judith Tannenbaum, ed., *Glenn Ligon: Unbecoming*, exh. cat. (Philadelphia: Institute of Contemporary Art, 1997), 52.

2. Of course de Kooning and Ligon shared a historical "moment" from 1960, the year of Ligon's birth, to de Kooning's death in 1997. Here, by the word "moments" I refer to the apogees of their respective careers during this shared period.

3. For an excellent discussion of Ligon's use of language across media, see Richard Meyer, "Borrowed Voices: Glenn Ligon and the Force of Language," in Tannenbaum, ed., *Glenn Ligon: Unbecoming*, 12–35. For a survey of Ligon's practice that emphasizes the role of the text paintings within it, see my "Glenn Ligon: Committed to Difficulty."

4. Rosalyn Deutsche, "Agoraphobia," in *Evictions: Art and Spatial Politics* (Cambridge: MIT Press, 1996), 299.

5. Thus these practices are vital to a history of the present committed to deriving a sustaining though impermanent language for those not-so-recent upheavals whose reverberations nevertheless can be felt today, sharply.

6. Mary Kelly, "Re-Viewing Modernist Criticism" (1981), in Brian Wallis, ed., *Art after Modernism: Rethinking Representation* (New York: New Museum of Contemporary Art and David R. Godine, 1984), 88.

7. See Roberta Smith, "'Lack of Location Is My Location,'" *New York Times*, 16 June 1991, H27.

8. See Michael Leja, *Reframing Abstract Expressionism: Subjectivity and Painting in the 1940s* (New Haven: Yale University Press, 1993); Anne Middleton Wagner's discussion of Lee Krasner's relationship to modernism in *Three Artists (Three Women): Modernism and the Art of Hesse, Krasner, and O'Keeffe* (Berkeley: University of California Press, 1996), esp. 1–28 and 105–190; and Ann Gibson, *Abstract Expressionism: Other Politics* (New Haven: Yale University Press, 1997).